finally sensed an opportunity to seize the initiative. Graeme stepped forward and set the tone with a brisk 84 in 100 balls, and Hashim soon settled into his rhythm.

Jacques also played his part, and it was his wicket that brought me to join Hashim at the crease with our total on 287 for three. I dared not fail and started carefully, only settling when I managed to pull a short ball from Mitchell Starc for four past long leg, and then executed a reverse sweep for three off Nathan Lyon. I reached lunch with 18 runs from 51 balls, and was starting to feel more confident and to move more freely.

We accelerated into the afternoon, scoring freely, and we had taken the score to 436 for four at the end of the 88th over when Hashim was out for a brilliant 196 from 221 balls. Dean Elgar, on his debut, fell soon afterwards, but it was crucial for us to keep the initiative and I managed to take my score from 89 to 101 with three boundaries in three balls from Nathan Lyon: a reverse sweep, a reverse paddle, another reverse sweep.

It feels so good when form returns and the ball starts to ping off your bat again. My first 50 had taken 98 balls, my second 50 came from 33 balls and my third 50 took 31 balls, and I was eventually dismissed for 169, including 21 boundaries and three sixes. This was better. I felt massively relieved.

With more than two days left in the Test, Graeme pressed home our advantage, delaying a declaration, taking the match further and further away from the home team. We batted on and were eventually all out for 569, the second-fastest score over 550 in Test history, setting Australia 632 to win.

Ricky Ponting had announced his retirement and we formed a guard of honour for him when he walked out to bat for Australia for the last time. He had played 168 Tests in 17 years of international cricket and given everything, and I admired the way he was able to walk away from the game on his own terms.

He struck a couple of trademark boundaries before being caught at